

“The druids—that is what the Celts call their magicians—hold nothing more sacred than the mistletoe.”

PLINY THE ELDER, *NATURAL HISTORY*, c. 77–79 CE

accounts of druids, but similar stories appear in old Welsh and Irish tales, which had Celtic origins. From the 8th century, Christian scholars recorded these stories in manuscripts such as the 12th-century *Book of Leinster* and *Book of the Dun Cow*. Druids in such myths are sometimes magicians with power over storms or other natural phenomena. In one Christian tale, when St. Patrick went to Ireland, a druid tried to discredit him by summoning a snowstorm, but Patrick dispersed it with the sign of the Cross.

Irish myths

Particularly rich in Celtic lore, Irish myths featured fantastical tales of bards, beautiful maidens, and warriors such as Cuchulainn, who had supernatural powers. They also told of the Tuatha Dé Danann, a race of magical beings said to be both ancient Irish gods and early inhabitants of Ireland. The tales were filled with magical deeds and weapons, such as the magic spear of the craftsman god Lugh, which threw itself and never missed. Many Irish myths also involved shape-shifting, reflecting the Celtic belief in the interconnectedness of all things. Hags who were offered help turned into beautiful damsels, while magicians transformed into animals such as deer and eagles, or turned foes into pigs or horses.

Among the most terrifying creatures in Celtic myth was the banshee, found in Irish, Scottish,

and Norman mythology. The Irish banshee, thought to haunt the burial mounds dotted across Ireland, was described as a wild woman with streaming hair, her eyes red from weeping. She was believed to announce death with her terrible wailing.

Fairy land

In Ireland, Celtic myths fed into a strong belief in other worlds, including Tir na n'Og—the Land of Eternal Youth. Accessed through magic mounds called sí, this land was peopled by the *aos sí*, who were thought to be Tuatha Dé Danann, condemned to the underworld after their defeat by the Celts. The *aos sí* were said to be fiercely protective of their special land. People took care not to anger them, often referring to them as The Fair Folk or Fairies.



▲ The sacred berries

This 19th-century illustration is an imagining of the ritual gathering of mistletoe. Pliny described this process: “Clad in a white robe the priest ascends the tree, and cuts the mistletoe with a golden sickle, which is received by others in a white cloak.”



► Ossian conjures up spirits

This painting, inspired by Scottish poet James Macpherson's “translations” of what he said were fragments of ancient poems, shows Ossian (Oisín), a bard of Irish myth who was said to have visited Tir na n'Og.